The Alumni Interview

By David Levinthal

IAN: It is never easy to have a college interview with your closeted boyfriend's father. Would I have applied to this university if I had known that of all the alumni in the greater metropolitan area, it would choose Mr. Wright to find me worthy or unworthy? Maybe. But maybe not. Thom took it worse than I did. [He] couldn't believe I wanted to go to a place that had helped spawn the person his father had become.

INTRODUCTION

It's difficult to deal with homophobic strangers, but it can be even more difficult dealing with relatives who reject homosexuality. These "loved ones" should love you no matter what and not judge you based on your sexual preferences. That's the way it should be . . . but not always.

Thom and Ian are in a loving relationship; and even though most of their friends know they are gay, Thom hasn't found the strength to come out to his stoic, judgmental father. Can Ian keep their secret during a college interview with Thom's father?

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IAN: Thom answered the door. We'd agreed on this beforehand. I didn't want to be in his house without seeing him. I wanted to know he was there.

It is a strange thing to meet your boyfriend's father when the father doesn't know you're his son's boyfriend-or even that his son ***has*** a boyfriend. It puts you at an advantage-you know more than he does-and also puts you at a disadvantage. The things you know aren't things you can let him know.

THOM: Dad, this is Ian.

MR. WRIGHT: Have a seat, Ian. Thank you, Thom.

IAN: I turned to Mr. Wright. ***I can do this,*** I thought. Then: ***And even if I can't, I have to***. Mr. Wright had clearly done the alumni interview thing a hundred times before. As if reciting a message beamed in from central campus, he talked about how this interview was not supposed to be a formal one; it was all about getting to know me, and me getting

to know the college where he had spent some of the best years of his life. He had a few questions to ask, and he was sure that I had many questions to ask as well.

In truth, I had already visited the campus twice and knew people who went there. I didn't have a single question to ask. Or, more accurately, the questions I wanted to ask didn't have anything to do with the university in question.

- ***Thom says you've never in all his life hugged him. Why is that?***
- ***What can I do to make you see how wonderful he is?***
- ***Don't you know how wrong it is when you wave a twenty dollar bill in front of your son and tell him that when he gets a girlfriend, you'll be happy to pay for the first date?***

And then I'd add: ***My father isn't like you at all.*** **So** ***don't tell me it's normal parent behavior.***

I am not by nature an angry person. But as this man kept saying he wanted to get to know me, I

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wanted to throw that phrase right back at him. How could he possibly get to know me when he didn't want to know his son?

MR. WRIGHT: Have you taken economics?

IAN: No.

MR. WRIGHT: *(harrumphing)* Why not?

IAN: I explained that our school offered only one economics class, and I had a conflict. A complete lie, but how would he know?

Judgmental. I considered the word ***judgmental.*** The mental state of always judging. His tone. I knew he wasn't singling me out. I knew this was probably the way he always was.

There were times I had gotten mad at Thom. Argument mad. Cutting-comment mad. Because his inability to be open made me a little closed. I didn't want to be a conditional boyfriend. I didn't want to be anybody's secret. As much as I said I understood, I never entirely understood.

Can't you just tell them? After they became the

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excuse for why we couldn't go out on Saturday. After they became the reason he pulled his hand away from mine as we were walking through town-***what if they drove by?*** But then I'd feel bad, feel wrong. Because I knew this was not the way he wanted it to be. That even though we were sixteen, we were still that one leap away from independence. We were still caught on the dependence side, staring over the divide. Now, bearing the brunt of his father's disapproval, I understood. Not all of it. But a little more.

MR. WRIGHT: *(expousing)* ... too many of you students dillydally. You spend your time on such expendable things. Like Thom. You know Thom, right? No focus. He has no focus. He wouldn't be right for this university. You show more promise. But I have to say, you need to make sure you don't spend time on expendable things ... "

IAN: And suddenly I was sick of it. I looked to the door and saw something. A shadow in the keyhole. And I knew. Thom had never left. He was on the outside of the door, holding his breath for me. Trying to keep quiet. Stay quiet, because his father was around.

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MR. WRIGHT: *(condescendingly)* What are your interests?

IAN: Your son in my room.

MR. WRIGHT: Excuse me?

IAN: The sun and the moon . . . Astronomy.

MR. WRIGHT: *(pleased)* I didn't know kids liked astronomy anymore. When I was a child, we all had telescopes. Now you just have telephones and televisions instead."

IAN: *(nodding emphatically)* You couldn't be more right, sir. A telescope is a fine instrument. And there's something about the stars ... *(dramatic pause)* Well, there's something about the stars that makes you realize both the smallness and the enormity of everything, isn't there?

MR. WRIGHT: Yes, yes, absolutely.

IAN: *(to audience)* Thom had first told me this as we lay on our backs on a golf course outside of town, too late for the twilight, but early enough to catch the rise of the moon, the pinprick arrival of the stars. His words were like a grasping. Now here was his father, agreeing with him, through me.

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I looked to the keyhole, to Thom's shadow there. Knowing he was near. Speaking to him in this code. Saying to his father what I've said to him. *(to Mr. Wright)* Sometimes I wish we could open ourselves up to each other as much as we do to the sky. To the smallness and the enormity.

MR. WRIGHT: *(looking at his notes)* I see . . . *(frowning)* What is the GSA?

IAN: It had now gone from uncomfortable to downright fierce. I tried to imagine him coming to one of our Gay-Straight Alliance meetings. I tried to imagine that if I told him what it was, he would understand. I tried to think of a way to avoid his shiver of revulsion, his dismissive disdain.

Thom had tried to signal him once. I'd placed a pink triangle pin on his bag after a meeting, and he didn't take it off when he got home. Instead, he put the bag in a spot where it could be seen. But it didn't work. Mr. Wright brushed past it. He didn't notice or didn't say. When all Thom wanted was for him to notice without being told.

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(to Mr. Wright as sincerely as possible) GSA stands for God Smiles Always, sir.

MR. WRIGHT: I didn't know the high school had one of those. How did it start?

IAN: *(earnestly)* Because of the school musical. A lot of the kids in the musical wanted to start it. It was *Jesus Christ Superstar,* sir. I think we were all moved by how much of a superstar Jesus was. It made us want to work to make God smile.

MR. WRIGHT: *(irritated)* And the school is okay with this?

IAN: Yes, sir. It's all about bringing people together.

MR. WRIGHT: *(looking at Ian's transcript)* It says here you were on the dance committee for the GSA?

IAN: *(nodding)* I was one of the coordinators. We wanted to create a wholesome atmosphere for our fellow students. We only played Christian dance music. It's like Christian rock music, only the beat is a little faster. The lyrics are mostly the same."

MR. WRIGHT: Did Thom go to that dance?

IAN: Yes, sir. I believe I saw him there. *(aside to audience)* ***In fact, he was my date.***

MR. WRIGHT: It also says you were involved in something

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called the Pride March?

IAN: Yes. We dress up as a pride of lions and we march. It's a school-spirit thing. Our mascot is a lion.

MR. WRIGHT: *(not amused)* Do you march in costume?

IAN: Yes. But we don't wear the heads of costumes. We're proud to be wearing them. We want people to know who we are.

MR. WRIGHT: *(looking again at Ian's paperwork)* It says the Pride March is tied to Coming Out Day.

IAN: *(to audience)* Damn. The transcript might as well have been written in lavender ink. *(to Mr. Wright with a fake laugh)* Oh, that. It's another school-spirit thing. First day of the football season, someone dresses up as a lion and comes out from under the bleachers onto the field. If we see its shadow, we know the season will be a long one. If not, we know it's pretty much over before it's begun. The whole school gets really into it.

MR. WRIGHT: *(slowly and deliberately)* I know what's going on here. And I don't like it one bit.

IAN: I'm sorry, sir, but ...

MR. WRIGHT: *(voice rapidly rising in agitation)* I will ***not*** be

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ridiculed in my own house. That you should have the ***presumption*** to apply to my alma mater and then to sit there and ***mock*** me. I know what you are, and I will not stand for it here.

IAN: *(to audience)* I wish I could say that I hurled a response right back at him. But mostly, I was stunned. To have such a blast directed at me. To be yelled at. I couldn't move. I couldn't figure out what to say. Then the door opened and Thom said

THOM: *(assertively)* Stop it. Stop it right now! If you say one more word, I'm going to scream. I don't give a s***what you say to me, but you leave Ian out of it, okay? You're being a total a**hole, and that's not okay.

IAN: Mr. Wright started to yell. But it was empty yelling. Desperate yelling. And while he yelled, Thom came over to me and took my hand. I stood up and together we faced his father. And his father fell silent. And his father began to cry. As if the world had ended. I could feel Thom shaking, the tremors of that world exploding. As we stood there. As we watched. As we broke free from limbo.

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I wanted to say, ***All you need to know about me is that I love your son. And if you get to know your son, you will know what that means.*** But the words were no longer mine to say.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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